How Good Can a Japanese Language Model Get in 30 GPU-Minutes?

Tokenization, model size and repeated data under a fixed budget

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Abstract

I train small Japanese language models from random weights, giving each model exactly 30 minutes of training on one GPU, and ask how to spend that budget. Across 12 such runs I find that: (1) splitting text into learned word pieces (BPE) beats splitting it into characters or raw bytes; (2) the best model size is 10–25 million parameters, and the best single model read 15–24 tokens of text per parameter, consistent with the rule of thumb of Hoffmann et al. [4]; and (3) for film-subtitle text, adding subtitles to the training mix helps far more than adding Wikipedia, and repeating the same 24 million subtitle tokens 11 times still helped slightly. I also test whether a model's surprise at a sentence can rate its difficulty for learners of Japanese. It does not help: adding the model's surprise to sentence length does not measurably improve predictions of a sentence's JLPT level, while adding the share of kanji does. All code, configurations and results are at `https://github.com/StarlightsJourney/tiny-japanese-lm`.

1 Declared setup

The project brief asks for three things to be fixed before any experiment. Table 1 states them.

Compute budget	30 minutes (1,800 s) of training per run on one NVIDIA L4 GPU (24 GB), rented from Modal. The clock runs only while the model is learning: reading a batch of text, measuring its errors and updating its weights. One such update is a *training step*. Pausing to score held-out text is not counted, so measuring progress never costs training time. Not counted either, as the brief allows: data preparation, tokenizer training and a preliminary learning-rate search (Section 4.3).
Initialisation	Every model starts from random weights. No pretrained weights, embeddings or other pretrained components are used. The tokenizers are trained on my own training data.
Evaluation objective	*Data:* held-out Japanese film and TV subtitles (primary) and held-out Japanese Wikipedia (secondary), never seen in training. *Metric:* bits per byte (BPB), defined in Section 3; lower is better. *Why:* BPB measures how well the model predicts real text it has not seen, which is what a language model is for. It is measured per byte of text rather than per token, so models that cut text into different pieces are compared on equal terms. Subtitles are primary because the model is meant for an app whose users learn from films and TV. *Protocol:* choices are made on a validation set; final numbers come from a separate test set. Every model is scored on the same subtitle test text.

Table 1: The declared budget, initialisation and evaluation objective.

2 Motivation

I am building Sheng, an offline desktop app for learning Japanese from films and TV. It shows live subtitles and lets the user save sentences as flashcards. It would help to know how hard each sentence is, so the app can point out lines just above the learner's level. This must run offline on a laptop, so any model has to be small. A language model is a natural candidate: if a sentence surprises the model, it might surprise a learner too. That raises two questions. How good a Japanese model can be trained cheaply, and how should the budget be spent? And is the model's surprise useful as a difficulty score?

3 Background and terms

Language model and loss. A language model reads text as a sequence of *tokens* and, at each position, assigns a probability to every possible next token. Training adjusts the model's *parameters* (its weights) to make the true next token more probable. The quantity minimised is the *cross-entropy loss*: the average of $-\ln p(\text{true next token})$. It is measured in nats per token (a nat is the natural-log unit of information; 1 nat $\approx$ 1.44 bits). It measures surprise: a model that always gives the true token probability 1 has loss 0.

Bits per byte. Loss per token cannot compare tokenizers: a tokenizer with longer tokens makes fewer, harder predictions over the same text. So I convert the total loss on a text into bits and divide by the text's length in UTF-8 bytes:

$$\text{BPB} = \frac{\sum_{\text{tokens}} -\log_2 p(\text{true next token})}{\text{number of UTF-8 bytes in the text}}.$$

This is the measure used for The Pile [2]. It is roughly the size, per byte, that the text would compress to using the model's predictions. Most Japanese characters take 3 bytes in UTF-8, and the subtitles average 2.8 bytes per character, so 1.33 BPB is about 3.7 bits per character.

What BPB leaves out. It measures prediction only. It says nothing about whether text the model generates is fluent or correct, or whether the model is useful for a downstream task (Section 5.5 tests one such task separately). It averages over all bytes, so common patterns dominate the score. And its absolute differences look small: a gain of 0.01 BPB is under 1% of the total.

Tokenizers. A tokenizer decides what the units of text are. I compare four (Table 2). *Byte*: every UTF-8 byte is a token, so one Japanese character becomes three tokens. *Char*: every character is a token. *BPE* (byte-pair encoding, 14): start from bytes and repeatedly merge the most frequent adjacent pair into a new token, until the vocabulary reaches a set size. The result is a vocabulary of common word pieces; I use the byte-level version of Radford et al. [13] with 4,096 or 16,384 tokens. Longer tokens mean each prediction covers more text. The cost is a larger vocabulary: the model learns one vector (an *embedding*) per token, so a larger vocabulary means more parameters and a larger final layer.

Tokenizer	Tokens	How 心配しないで、俺がやるから。("Don't worry, I'll do it.") is split
byte	42	`e5` | `bf` | `83` | `e9` | `85` | `8d` | `e3` | `81` | `97` | … (one token per byte)
char	14	心 | 配 | し | な | い | で | 、 | 俺 | が | や | る | か | ら | 。
bpe4k	8	心配 | しない | で | 、 | 俺が | やる | から | 。
bpe16k	7	心配 | しないで | 、 | 俺が | やる | から | 。

Table 2: One subtitle-style sentence (42 bytes) cut by each tokenizer, using the tokenizers trained in this project. With 16k tokens, しないで ("don't") becomes a single token.

Budgets. Kaplan et al. [5] found that loss falls smoothly as parameters, data and compute grow. Hoffmann

et al. [4] found that for a fixed amount of compute, parameters and training tokens should grow together, at about 20 tokens per parameter. Training compute is roughly $C \approx 6ND$ floating-point operations (FLOPs) for N parameters and D tokens. Their models had 70M to 16B parameters; whether the ratio holds for a few million is untested. Muennighoff et al. [11] studied the case where unique text runs out. They found that up to about four *epochs* (passes over the same data) is almost as good as fresh data, with value decaying after that. Japanese subtitles are such a scarce source.

Surprise and difficulty. Surprisal theory holds that the surprise of a word under a probabilistic language model predicts how hard it is for people to read [3, 7]. Language-model scores have also been used to rate text readability without labelled data [9]. For learners of Japanese, Benedetti et al. [1] use pretrained language models to suggest example sentences. My question is whether a tiny model trained from scratch carries any of this signal.

4 Method

4.1 Data

Subtitles are the Japanese side of JESC [12], 2.8M lines. I normalise each line, drop lines with no Japanese characters, and remove exact duplicates, because subtitles repeat short lines such as “hai” (“yes”) constantly and a line in both training and test data would inflate test scores. A hash of each line sends it to training, validation or test (99/0.5/0.5), so the split never changes. **Wikipedia** is the first ∼600 MB of the November 2023 Japanese dump; each article goes wholly to one split. Table 3 gives the sizes.

Source	Train lines	Train text	Validation / test lines	Validation / test text
Subtitles (JESC)	2,476,413	118.5 MB	12,564 / 12,683	0.61 / 0.61 MB
Wikipedia (Japanese)	3,097,333	561.8 MB	14,707 / 20,765	2.96 / 3.82 MB

Table 3: Data after cleaning and splitting.

4.2 Model and training

The model is a decoder-only transformer [17], the architecture of GPT-style models, adapted from nanoGPT [6]. It reads 512 tokens at a time (its *context*) and is trained on batches of 64 such sequences. Weights are updated with AdamW [8], a standard optimiser. Each sequence is drawn from subtitles with a fixed probability, the *subtitle share*. By default this is the natural share: the fraction of all training tokens that are subtitles, 16% for BPE-16k. The *learning rate* sets how large each update is. It rises over the first 2% of the budget, then falls smoothly to 10% of its peak by the end. The schedule follows elapsed time rather than step count, because under a time budget the number of steps is not known in advance.

I compare four model sizes: **xs**, **s**, **m** and **l**, with 4, 6, 8 and 12 layers and 3.2M, 10.6M, 25.2M and 59.0M parameters, not counting the token embeddings. The *baseline* is size s with BPE-16k and the natural subtitle share. Each experiment changes one thing from the baseline.

4.3 Learning-rate search

A learning rate that suits one model size can be too high for another, so a single rate would have handicapped some sizes. I chose each size's peak rate with 6-minute runs, picking the best validation BPB. My first guesses were too high for s, m and l: each preferred the lowest rate tried. I extended the search downwards until every chosen rate had a worse rate on both sides (Appendix A). The search mattered. The baseline's tuned rate scored 0.028 BPB better than my first guess, more than several effects reported below.

4.4 Evaluation details

Validation BPB is measured every 2 minutes on up to 200k tokens per source. Test BPB is measured once, at the end, on up to 2M tokens per source. Every model scores the whole subtitle test set. Two caps affect what text is scored. Validation uses the first 200k tokens, which is less text for tokenizers with short tokens. And the byte model's Wikipedia test score covers only the first 2.0 MB of 3.8 MB. Comparisons between tokenizers therefore rest on the subtitle test set.

5 Results

Figure 1 shows how every model improved during training. All results are single runs except the baseline, which was run with three random seeds to measure noise.

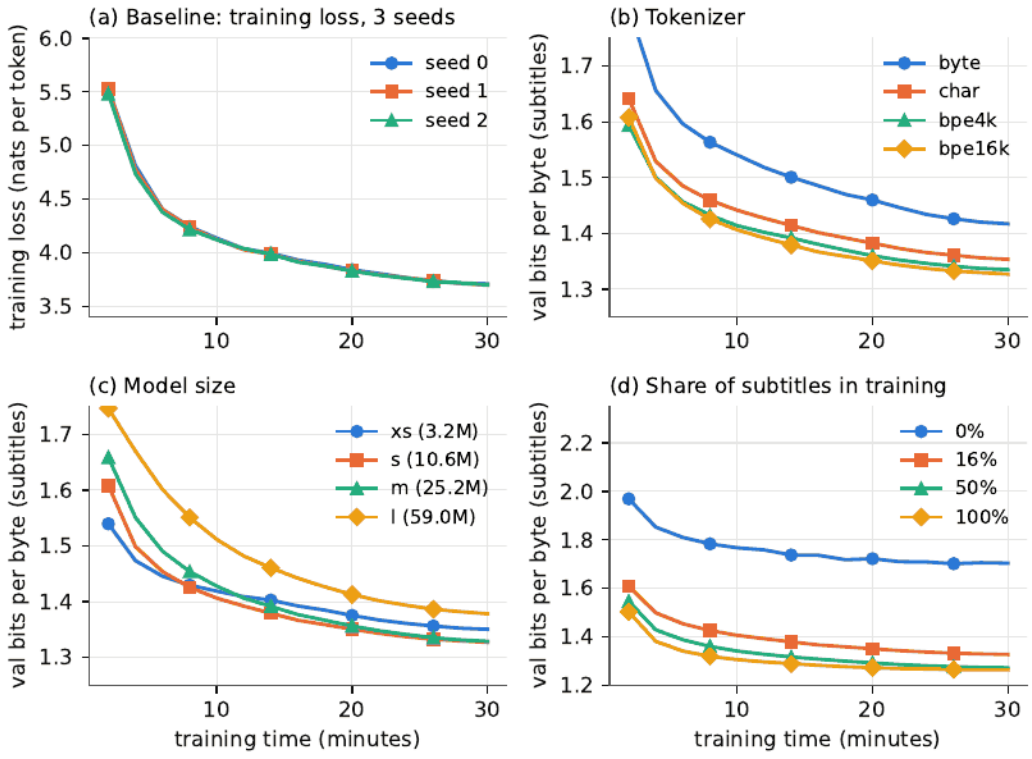


Figure 1: Learning curves. (a) The training loss of the baseline, for three random seeds. (b)–(d) Validation BPB on subtitles during training, for each experiment. Every model was still improving when its 30 minutes ran out.

5.1 How much do results vary between runs?

Finding: the noise between runs is about 0.0015 BPB, much smaller than most effects studied here.

The three baseline seeds gave test BPB of 1.3343, 1.3326 and 1.3313 on subtitles (standard deviation 0.0015) and validation BPB of 1.3270, 1.3251 and 1.3251 (standard deviation 0.0011). The seed changes the random starting weights and the order of training batches. Under a time budget, the GPU's speed also matters: these runs processed between 141k and 145k tokens per second. Their training losses are almost indistinguishable (Figure 1a). When two single runs differ by less than about three standard deviations of their difference ($3 \times \sqrt{2} \times 0.0011 \approx 0.005$ BPB on validation), I treat them as tied. Three seeds give only a rough estimate of the noise, so I rely on gaps near this threshold only when other evidence agrees.

5.2 Tokenizer

Finding: learned word pieces beat characters, and characters beat bytes. BPE-16k is best.

The byte model processes the most tokens per second, but each token is one byte, so in 30 minutes it reads the least text, and its 512-token context holds only about 170 Japanese characters (Table 4). Characters and BPE tokens each cover more text, so those models read more and see more context at once.

Tokenizer	Total params	Tokens per second	Text read in 30 min	Text in one context	Test BPB, subtitles	Test BPB, Wikipedia
byte	10.9M	264k	0.48 GB	512 B	1.430	1.327
char	12.9M	206k	1.00 GB	1.4 KB	1.362	1.205
bpe4k	12.4M	217k	1.41 GB	2.1 KB	1.344	1.173
bpe16k	17.1M	141k	1.17 GB	2.6 KB	**1.334**	**1.156**

Table 4: Tokenizer comparison (size s, 30 minutes each). "Total params" includes the token embeddings, which grow with the vocabulary.

BPE-16k beats BPE-4k by 0.008 on validation, 0.010 on the subtitle test and 0.017 on the Wikipedia test. The validation gap is above the noise threshold, and both test sets agree, so I take it as real. It is not because BPE-16k read more: its larger output layer makes it the slowest model, and it read 1.17 GB of text against 1.41 GB for BPE-4k. Two differences remain that could explain it. Its context covers more text (2.6 KB against 2.1 KB), and its embedding table adds 6.3M parameters, against 1.6M for BPE-4k. I held the non-embedding size fixed, as is usual, but this means the larger vocabulary also had more parameters in total. My experiments cannot separate these two causes.

5.3 Model size

Finding: the best size is a flat region between 10M and 25M parameters. The best model read 15–24 tokens per parameter.

The smallest model read the most text, 128 tokens per parameter, and still did worse than s (Table 5): it lacks the capacity to use the data. The largest model read only 1.5 tokens per parameter and did worst: it is far from trained. Sizes s and m differ by 0.002 on validation, below the noise threshold, so they tie.

Size	Params (non-emb.)	Params (total)	Peak learning rate	Tokens read	Tokens per param	Val BPB, subtitles	Test BPB, subtitles
xs	3.2M	7.5M	3×10^{-3}	404M	128	1.351	1.358
s	10.6M	17.1M	1×10^{-3}	254M	24	**1.327**	**1.334**
m	25.2M	33.8M	7.5×10^{-4}	161M	6.4	1.329	1.336
l	59.0M	69.8M	5×10^{-4}	89M	1.5	1.378	1.386

Table 5: Model-size comparison (BPE-16k, natural subtitle share). Tokens per parameter uses non-embedding parameters.

The winner, s, read 24 tokens per non-embedding parameter, or 15 per parameter if the embedding table is counted. Both are close to the ∼20 of Hoffmann et al. [4]. Their rule, $N \approx \sqrt{C/120}$, predicts an optimal size of about 15M parameters for this run's 2.6×10^{16} FLOPs. s has 17.1M in total. This is one budget and four sizes, so it is consistent with their rule rather than a test of it.

Equal time is not equal compute. Larger models make better use of the GPU, so in the same 30 minutes l performed about twice the computation of xs (3.7 against 1.8×10^{16} FLOPs). Figure 2 plots the same runs against compute instead of time. At 1.8×10^{16} FLOPs, all xs used, validation BPB is 1.351 (xs), 1.347 (s), 1.374 (m) and 1.455 (l). At equal compute, s now clearly beats m. This suggests that a time budget favours larger models somewhat. The comparison is not exact, though: m and l are read off part-way through their runs, before their learning rates had finished decreasing, which makes them look worse than a run planned for that compute would.

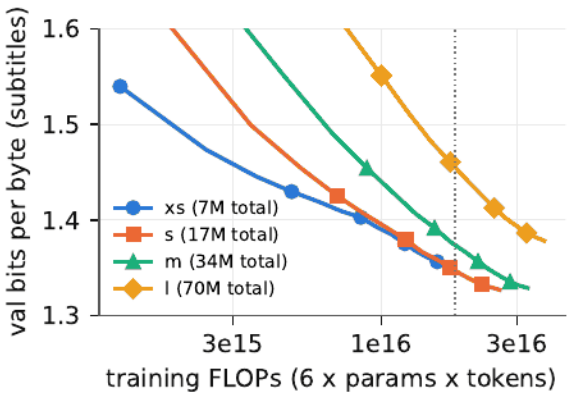


Figure 2: Validation BPB against compute. Dotted line: all the compute xs used.

5.4 Data mix and repetition

Finding: for subtitle text, subtitles in training matter far more than Wikipedia, and repeating them 11 times still helped slightly.

A model trained only on Wikipedia scores 1.718 on subtitles. Moving 16% of training to subtitles improves that by 0.38, the largest effect in this study (Table 6, Figure 3). Each further increase helps less: 0.055 from 16% to 50%, and 0.008 from 50% to 100%. The last gain is small but above the noise threshold. It comes from reading the same 24M subtitle tokens 10.8 times, well beyond the four passes that Muennighoff et al. [11] found to be nearly as good as new data.

Subtitle share	Passes over subtitles	Test BPB, subtitles	Test BPB, Wikipedia	Validation − training gap
0%	0	1.718	**1.144**	0.040
16% (natural)	1.7	1.334	1.156	0.035
50%	5.5	1.279	1.203	0.034
100%	10.8	**1.270**	2.447	0.100

Table 6: Data-mix comparison (size s, BPE-16k). The last column is validation BPB minus training BPB at the end of the run, over the run's own mix of sources; the 16% value is the mean of three seeds.

Repetition did leave a trace. The gap between validation and training BPB, a sign of memorisation, stays at 0.034–0.040 up to 5.5 passes, including the run with no subtitles at all. At 10.8 passes it rises to 0.100. This suggests the model has begun to memorise repeated lines, though its validation score was still improving when training ended (Figure 1d). In the 50% run the gap is averaged over both sources, so memorisation of subtitles there could be hidden by the Wikipedia half.

Specialising costs general ability. On Wikipedia, the 50% model is 0.047 worse than the baseline, and the subtitles-only model's BPB more than doubles (2.447 against 1.156). For an app that sees only subtitles, the 50% mix keeps most of the subtitle gain while staying usable on other Japanese text.

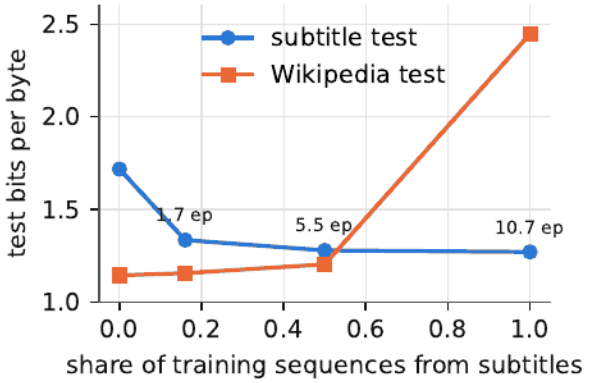


Figure 3: Test BPB as the subtitle share grows, labelled with passes (epochs) over the subtitle data.

5.5 Does surprise track difficulty?

Finding: model surprise adds nothing measurable to sentence length. Length plus kanji share is the better difficulty score.

Test set. I took Japanese sentences of 5–40 characters from Tatoeba [16], split them into words with fugashi [10], and labelled each with the JLPT level of its hardest word, using open JLPT word lists [15]. The JLPT is the standard Japanese proficiency test, with levels from N5 (easiest) to N1 (hardest). I kept 400 sentences per level. Each sentence is scored by its BPB under the model. I measure agreement with level by Spearman's ρ, a correlation of rankings: $+1$ means harder sentences always score higher, and 0 means no relation.

Model BPB barely tracks level (ρ = 0.05–0.12, top row of Table 7), while sentence length alone reaches 0.27 and kanji share 0.21. Figure 4 shows why. The easiest sentences have the highest BPB, and the easiest sentences are also the shortest. Across all sentences, BPB falls as length grows ($\rho = -0.27$ for the baseline). A likely reason is that the start of any sentence is hard to predict, and in a short sentence the start is a large share of the bytes. Two effects pull in opposite directions: harder words raise BPB, and the greater length of hard sentences lowers it.

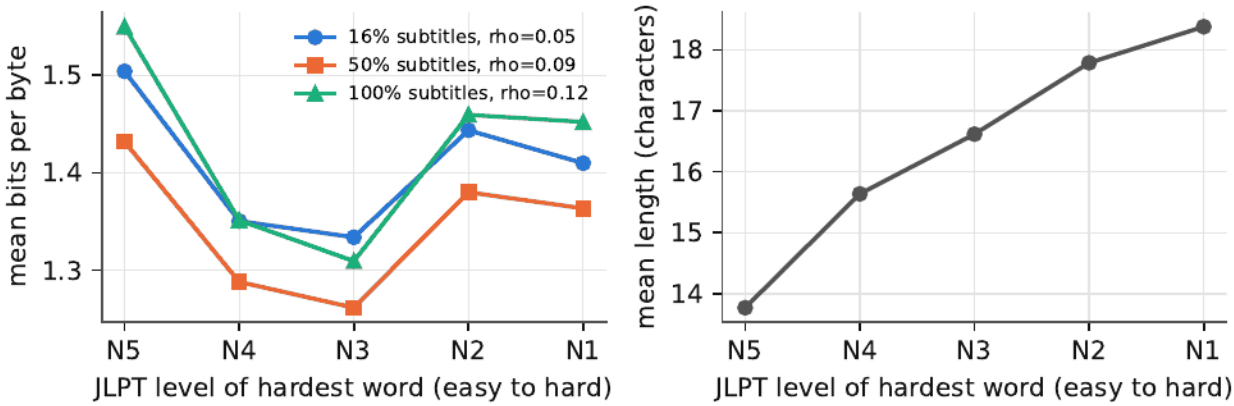


Figure 4: Left: mean BPB of the difficulty-set sentences at each JLPT level, for models trained with 16%, 50% and 100% subtitles. Right: mean sentence length at each level.

Holding length fixed reveals a real but weak link between BPB and level, $\rho \approx 0.13$–0.17, with intervals well above zero. The models trained on more subtitles score slightly higher, but their intervals overlap, so I cannot claim a trend.

Score (Spearman ρ with JLPT level)	16% subtitles	50% subtitles	100% subtitles
Model BPB	0.05	0.09	0.12
Model BPB, with length held fixed (95% interval)	0.13 (0.09–0.18)	0.16 (0.11–0.20)	0.17 (0.12–0.21)
Score fitted on 80% of sentences, tested on the other 20% (5-fold):			
Length	0.26	0.26	0.26
Length + model BPB	0.27	0.27	0.27
Length + kanji share	**0.36**	**0.36**	**0.36**
Length + kanji share + model BPB	0.36	0.36	0.36

Table 7: Difficulty results on 2,000 Tatoeba sentences. Length and kanji share do not depend on the model, so their rows repeat across columns.

The practical test is whether the model improves a prediction that free features already make. It does not. Fitted on part of the data and tested on the rest, length alone gives $\rho = 0.26$, and adding model BPB raises it by only 0.004–0.006 (for the baseline, 95% interval -0.003 to $+0.016$). Adding kanji share instead raises it to 0.36, and adding the model on top of that changes nothing.

6 Limitations

- **One budget, one GPU type.** The best size and the tokenizer ranking may change at other budgets or on faster hardware.
- **Learning rates were tuned on short runs.** They were chosen with 6-minute runs on BPE-16k and reused for 30-minute runs and for every tokenizer.
- **Noise from three seeds.** The noise estimate is rough and comes from the baseline only.
- **Vocabulary and size are linked.** Larger vocabularies also add embedding parameters, so the tokenizer comparison mixes the two.
- **Validation text differs across tokenizers.** The validation cap covers less text for short-token tokenizers. The subtitle test set, scored in full by every model, gives the same ranking.
- **The difficulty labels favour length.** A sentence's level is its hardest word, and longer sentences are more likely to contain a rare word. The labels ignore grammar, which a language model might capture. Ratings by teachers, or graded-reader texts, would be a fairer test.

7 Conclusion

With 30 minutes on one L4, the best Japanese model here has 10–25M parameters and a 16k BPE vocabulary, and is trained with a large share of text from the target domain. The best single model read 15–24 tokens per parameter, in line with Hoffmann et al. [4]. The largest effect was the training data: adding subtitles improved subtitle BPB by 0.38, several times more than any tokenizer or size change. For Sheng, the difficulty experiment gives a clear negative answer: the app should rate sentences by length and kanji share, not by model surprise.

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A Learning-rate search

Size	Validation BPB on subtitles after 6 minutes (peak learning rate)			
xs	1.4404 (1.5×10^{-3})	**1.4387** (3×10^{-3})	1.4464 (6×10^{-3})	
s	1.5122 (5×10^{-4})	**1.4676** (1×10^{-3})	1.4958 (2×10^{-3})	1.5273 (4×10^{-3})
m	1.5799 (3.75×10^{-4})	**1.5289** (7.5×10^{-4})	1.5937 (1.5×10^{-3})	1.5901 (3×10^{-3})
l	1.6966 (2.5×10^{-4})	**1.6787** (5×10^{-4})	1.6864 (1×10^{-3})	1.6923 (2×10^{-3})

Table 8: The fifteen preliminary runs (BPE-16k). The chosen rate for each size is in bold and has a worse rate on both sides.

B Training details

Pre-norm transformer blocks with GELU activations, learned position embeddings, no bias terms, and input and output embeddings shared. Widths are 256, 384, 512 and 640 for xs, s, m and l. Batches of 64 sequences of 512 tokens (32,768 tokens per step), sampled at random positions. AdamW with $\beta = (0.9, 0.95)$, weight decay 0.1 on weight matrices, gradient clipping at 1.0, bfloat16 arithmetic. Learning-rate warmup over the first 2% of the time budget, then cosine decay to 10% of the peak. The four tokenizers are lossless: characters outside a vocabulary fall back to their UTF-8 bytes, so every model can be scored on exactly the same text. The character vocabulary keeps characters seen at least 5 times (5,276 tokens with byte fallbacks); both BPE vocabularies were learned from 40 MB of each source. All runs together cost US$8.16 on Modal.